we're looking to prepare a grant application for https://frymatic.us/FTSArcade in order to get a grant from https://leverforchange.org/open-calls/boundless-san-francisco/ this is a $50,000,000 grant which we aim to receive how do we prepare for stage 1

Prepare Stage 1 as a San Francisco public-benefit proposal that uses FTSArcade as a tool—not simply a request to fund more games. First, confirm that your team registered before September 11: the application deadline was extended to October 15, 2026, at 5 p.m. Pacific Time, but the published registration deadline has already passed. [1]

My recommendation is to resolve eligibility immediately, then build a focused case around a specific community need, credible local delivery, measurable results, and a justified funding request.

First: confirm you can apply

As of October 12, you have three days until the published application deadline—but only registered applicants are invited to complete the application. [1]

1. **Find your registration confirmation.** Identify the registered Lead Organization, primary contact, and application invitation.
2. **Open the application and copy its questions.** Record every word limit, attachment requirement, budget field, and submission condition before drafting.
3. **If you did not register, contact the competition immediately.** Ask whether any exception is available at boundless-sf@submittable.com; do not assume the application extension also reopened registration—the published guidance does not say that. [1]
4. **If another organization registered, confirm the permitted arrangement.** Do not assume you can transfer its registration or replace its project without approval.

This is the first go/no-go decision. Without a valid route to submit, I would avoid spending the remaining days writing a full application.

What Stage 1 achieves

Stage 1 is the initial application and review process leading to finalist selection, not an immediate $50 million award; finalists receive development support before preparing a comprehensive investment prospectus for the final award decision. [1]

The published process includes administrative eligibility review, mandatory peer review, expert evaluation, and finalist selection expected by June 2027, followed by final award selection in fall 2027. [1]

Two implications for your preparation:

- **Make the initial case convincing, but do not confuse it with the later investment prospectus.** Prioritize the actual application questions.
- **Assign someone to the post-submission obligations.** Applicants must review at least four other applications; failing to complete that review can terminate participation. [2]

Also, **$50 million is the maximum, not a guaranteed award size**: the competition describes final awards between $10 million and $50 million. [1]

Resolve the legal applicant

FTSArcade is the project; you need to identify the legal organization responsible for receiving, controlling, and reporting on the money.

The current rules allow several entity types, including qualifying nonprofits, government entities, and for-profit organizations; individuals and certain single-member LLCs treated as individuals for tax purposes cannot lead an application. Official rules

For-profit recipients must comply with expenditure-responsibility requirements, and all award spending must serve charitable purposes rather than primarily enriching owners or shareholders. Official rules

Prepare this internal eligibility file:

- Legal name, jurisdiction, entity type, and registration documents
- Tax status and relevant determination documents
- Authorized signatory and governing-body approval
- Recent financial statements and current operating budget
- Proposed project leadership and financial controls
- Ownership or licensing documentation for the platform and its assets

If the proposed applicant is outside the United States, obtain written clarification: the rules list foreign-entity categories, but other wording in the FAQ and definitions refers to U.S.-based organizations. Official rules Official FAQ

A fiscal sponsor or established local lead may be worth considering, but it must genuinely control the project and grant—not merely lend its name. That control is required by the rules. [2]

Define the public benefit

The material you shared shows a browser-based arcade with playable games and work-in-progress builds; it does not, by itself, establish San Francisco community outcomes.[3]

My assessment is that the missing grant case is not "more features." It is **who benefits, what changes for them, and why this platform is a credible way to produce that change.**

Choose one primary purpose rather than combining several loosely related promises:

Possible direction	Proposed role for FTSArcade	Evidence you would need
Creative workforce pathways	Entry point into structured game-development training, paid projects, and employment support	Participant learning, completed portfolios, paid placements, employer demand
Accessible community learning	Platform for facilitated digital-literacy and creative-technology programs	Demonstrated learning gains, accessibility testing, partner delivery capacity
Community connection	Tool for recurring, facilitated activities through neighborhood organizations	Repeat participation, validated belonging measures, evidence beyond website traffic

These are **possible project designs, not established benefits of FTSArcade.** Choose only a direction your team can support with relevant experience, evidence, and real partnerships.

A useful drafting framework is:

> For **[defined San Francisco population]**, we will address **[documented problem]** through **[specific intervention]**, using FTSArcade for **[defined function]**, delivered with **[confirmed partners]**, to achieve **[measurable outcomes]** over **[time period]**.

The project must primarily benefit people living and working in San Francisco, with no more than 25% of activities aimed at benefiting the broader Bay Area outside city limits.[2]

A globally accessible website alone is therefore not a sufficient local-delivery plan.

Build around the rubric

The competition evaluates **Transformative Ambition, Viability, Evidence of Results, and Durability.**[1]

Use those criteria as your internal review structure:

Criterion	What your application should demonstrate	What to prepare
Transformative Ambition	A meaningful change in opportunity or conditions—not just a larger arcade	Problem statement, theory of change, explanation of what changes structurally
Viability	A credible way to deliver in San Francisco	Named leadership, local partners, rollout schedule, staffing and risk plan
Evidence of Results	Reasons to believe the intervention can work	Existing results, pilot findings, relevant external evidence, explicit limitations
Durability	Benefits that continue beyond the grant	Long-term operating model, institutional adoption, ownership and maintenance arrangements

The headings above are official criteria; the preparation suggestions are my recommendations. [1]

For an early-stage project, the competition allows relevant analogous evidence and a well-reasoned theory of change where direct results are limited. Nevertheless, do not treat game engagement as proof of educational, employment, or wellbeing outcomes. [1]

Separate three kinds of claims throughout the application: what you have already achieved, what external evidence suggests, and what you propose to test.

Justify the funding request

Do not start with $50 million and invent enough activities to spend it. Build the intervention and calculate what it genuinely requires.

Prepare a five-year planning budget with:

- Community delivery and local partner costs
- Participant support or compensation, where appropriate
- Program staff and management
- Technology development, accessibility, security, and maintenance
- Independent evaluation and data collection
- Legal, safeguarding, insurance, and financial administration
- Indirect costs, with a clearly explained allocation method

The rules permit indirect costs up to 29% of direct project or activity costs, within the award limit—not 29% of the total award. Official rules

For each major line, document the quantity, unit cost, source of estimate, timing, and intended result. For a $50 million request, I would also prepare lower-cost scenarios and explain what would be lost at smaller funding levels.

The central question is: what verified scale of public benefit makes this amount proportionate?

Assemble your working packet

This is my recommended preparation packet, **not a verified list of required portal attachments**. I have not obtained your actual application form, so its questions and limits must govern the final submission.

1. **Project brief:** Problem, beneficiaries, intervention, funding request, and expected outcomes.
2. **Local-needs evidence:** Current San Francisco data and documented community input.
3. **Theory of change:** Activities → immediate outputs → participant outcomes → lasting change.
4. **Delivery plan:** Phases, responsibilities, partners, dependencies, and decision gates.
5. **Evidence register:** Every material claim, supporting source, limitation, and evidence gap.

6. **Budget workbook:** Costs, assumptions, annual spending, and sustainability.
7. **Organizational-capacity file:** Leadership experience, finances, governance, and controls.
8. **Risk register:** Adoption, accessibility, safeguarding, privacy, implementation, and financial risks.
9. **Platform-rights file:** Code, artwork, audio, branding, third-party licenses, and contributor agreements.

The rules require appropriate rights and licenses for third-party material included in the application, making an IP review particularly important for a game platform. Official rules

Seek written confirmation of partner roles now, but distinguish confirmed commitments from discussions. Formal collaboration MOUs are not collected in the initial application, although finalists may be required to provide them. Official rules

Your three-day work plan

October 12 — Resolve the gates

- Confirm registration and applicant eligibility.
- Extract the actual application questions.
- Select one primary public-benefit outcome.
- Assign an application lead, budget owner, and final approver.
- Contact prospective local partners without overstating their involvement.

October 13 — Build the case

- Draft responses against the four criteria.
- Assemble existing evidence and document gaps honestly.
- Build the budget from delivery assumptions.
- Define beneficiaries, outcome measures, and sustainability.

October 14 — Challenge and finalize

- Have an independent reader assess credibility and clarity.
- Verify costs, sources, partner claims, rights, and eligibility.
- Enter and check all portal fields.
- Aim to submit before the final day.

October 15 — Submission buffer

- Resolve any remaining technical issues.
- Retain the submission confirmation.
- Assign responsibility for forthcoming peer review.

The FAQ says submitted applications cannot be edited, so complete the factual and budget checks before pressing submit.[1]

To turn this into your actual Stage 1 draft, the most important next inputs are: your registration status, the legal applicant, the application questions, your intended San Francisco beneficiaries, confirmed local relationships, and any existing usage or outcome evidence.

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How do we handle the 501c3 lead organization requirement

The practical route is to have an eligible existing nonprofit serve as the legal Lead Organization—either as your fiscal sponsor or as the organization running the program with FTSArcade as a delivery partner. The competition explicitly permits fiscal sponsorship, but the sponsor must genuinely control the grant funds and oversee the project, not simply lend you its 501(c)(3) status. [18] [19]

I also need to correct my earlier advice: the published eligibility list does not clearly authorize an ordinary for-profit company to lead. Although another section discusses for-profit recipients, that inconsistency is not a safe basis for claiming eligibility; obtain written clarification if you want to pursue that route. [18]

Choose your structure

For FTSArcade, I would consider these two arrangements:

Arrangement	Legal and operational structure	When I would recommend it
Fiscal sponsorship	An eligible nonprofit leads, receives the award, and exercises financial and project oversight; your team delivers the sponsored project under an agreed arrangement. [18]	When your team has a credible charitable program but needs nonprofit infrastructure
Nonprofit-led partnership	An eligible nonprofit owns responsibility for the program and selects FTSArcade as a technology or implementation partner; the lead can select contractors and other partners. [20]	When an established San Francisco organization already serves your intended beneficiaries

My preference for a $50 million proposal would be a substantive nonprofit-led partnership, unless you already have a fiscal sponsor with the capacity and willingness to supervise a project of this size. A strong partner should improve the actual program—not just solve the eligibility paperwork.

What the nonprofit must control

The Lead Organization must have legal responsibility for the funds, reporting obligations, and actual authority to direct and supervise the proposed solution. [18]

That means your agreement should address:

- **Budget authority:** Who approves expenditures, changes, and payments.
- **Program accountability:** Who decides whether activities fulfill the charitable purpose.
- **Staff and contractors:** Who hires, contracts, supervises, and handles conflicts of interest.

- **Reporting:** Who collects evidence and submits financial and outcome reports.
- **Technology and IP:** What the nonprofit can use, for how long, and what happens if your relationship ends.
- **Termination:** How remaining funds, unfinished work, and participant commitments are handled.

These are recommended negotiation points, not a verified list of required application attachments. Have nonprofit counsel review the arrangement before signing.

Avoid a "receive the money and immediately pass it all to us" arrangement. That would not establish the discretion, control, and supervision required of the lead. [18]

Keep the charitable project distinct

I recommend separating **FTSArcade the platform** from **the San Francisco charitable program that uses it**.

For example, a nonprofit might run a community creative-technology program, while your team supplies the arcade platform, training tools, and technical services. This is a proposed structure—not evidence that your current arcade already delivers those outcomes.

Before approaching a partner, prepare clear answers to:

- What specific San Francisco population will benefit?
- What services will participants receive beyond access to games?
- What outcomes will you measure?
- What existing evidence supports the intervention?
- What will the nonprofit control?
- What will your team retain, including existing code and branding?
- Will your team be paid, and how will compensation and licensing costs be justified?

You do **not** need to offer ownership of all your existing IP as an opening position. Instead, propose sufficient, durable usage rights for the charitable program and negotiate the details with the lead and counsel.

Find an appropriate lead

Two organizations worth investigating—not confirmed partners—are:

- Community Initiatives: A dedicated fiscal sponsor offering nonprofit infrastructure, including financial management and compliance support. [21]
- Intersection for the Arts: Offers fiscal sponsorship for arts and culture projects, with stated fit criteria including community-based, noncommercial work in the Bay Area. [22]

Neither should be assumed willing to sponsor FTSArcade, capable of accommodating this particular award, or available before your deadline. Intersection's published pages also give conflicting application-availability information, so contact it directly rather than relying on an online application status. [23] [22]

For the nonprofit-led route, prioritize organizations already delivering the specific service you propose—such as creative education or workforce development—rather than approaching unrelated charities.

Ask prospective leads these questions immediately:

1. Does the proposed program fit your mission?
2. Will you accept legal responsibility and actual project oversight?
3. Can you administer a potential multiyear award up to $50 million?
4. What due diligence and board approval do you require?
5. What fees, staffing costs, and reporting obligations would apply?
6. Can you authorize an application within the available time?

Resolve registration before committing

A sponsor does not automatically fix a missed registration deadline. The competition required registration by September 11, 2026, and its FAQ says fiscal-sponsor information belongs in designated registration and application sections.[20] [24]

Before changing the applicant or spending money on sponsorship, ask the competition administrators:

> "FTSArcade is preparing a fiscally sponsored proposal. Our registration status is [state it accurately]. Can an eligible fiscal sponsor be added or substituted as the Lead Organization at this point? Which documents and approvals must be in place before submission?"

Also ask whether the sponsor must already have completed its own registration. **Do not assume a new sponsor can inherit your registration or that an existing registrant can add a new project without approval.**

Prepare the sponsor packet

I would send a short, decision-ready packet rather than a long pitch:

- Two-page charitable-program description
- Defined San Francisco beneficiaries and delivery partners
- Draft budget, including your team's proposed payments
- Team biographies and evidence of relevant experience
- Platform ownership and third-party licensing information
- Proposed governance and division of responsibilities
- Exact grant questions, deadline, and registration status

Request the prospective lead's IRS determination letter, legal name, EIN, public-charity classification, financial information, and written authorization to use its details. Verify the

applicable eligibility category: the common public-charity route requires 501(c)(3) status **and** classification under 509(a)(1) or 509(a)(2), while other specified categories also exist. [18]

The next decision depends on two facts: did you register by September 11, and is FTSArcade currently owned by an individual, a company, or a nonprofit?

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do we have to open a foundation?

No—you do not have to create a foundation. Boundless San Francisco explicitly allows an existing eligible nonprofit to act as the **fiscal sponsor and Lead Organization** for your project. [39]

Your practical options

Option	What it means for FTSArcade
Use a fiscal sponsor	Your project operates under an eligible nonprofit's sponsorship; the sponsor controls the grant funds and is named in the grant agreement if you win. [40]
Partner with an existing nonprofit	The nonprofit leads the charitable program, with your team potentially serving as a technology or implementation partner selected by the lead. [39]
Create your own eligible nonprofit	For the standard public-charity route, the organization must already have an effective IRS determination letter recognizing 501(c)(3) status and the required public-charity classification; merely registering an organization is insufficient. [39]

My recommendation is to pursue an existing nonprofit, not create a foundation solely for this application. Look for genuine mission alignment, San Francisco delivery capability, and the capacity to oversee a large grant.

What you cannot shortcut

A sponsor cannot simply lend you its nonprofit status and hand over the money: the lead must exercise actual legal and operational control, supervision, and financial reporting responsibility. [39]

Likewise, **"foundation" is not itself the eligibility requirement**—the rules distinguish specific qualifying categories, including public charities and private operating foundations. [39]

Before incorporating anything or paying a sponsor, ask the competition whether a sponsor can be added to your application at this stage; its FAQ requires sponsor details in designated registration and application fields but does not establish permission to substitute a lead now. [40]

Did your team register by September 11, and under whose legal name? That determines the immediate next step—not whether you open a foundation.

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here's more info from their website:

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Boundless SF: Powered by Crankstart
Organization Readiness Tool
About the Organization Readiness Tool
The goal of the Organization Readiness Tool is to allow potential applicants to devel

In advance of submitting an application to the Competition, which we know takes time

The Organization Readiness Tool is a standard and important feature of all Lever for

Which of the following best describes your organization? The Lead Organization is a s

An entity based in the United States and/or U.S. Territories that has received a tax

A nonprofit organization for a fiscally sponsored project, provided that the nonprofi

An entity based in the United States and/or U.S. Territories that has received a tax

A public or private college, junior college, university, or other similar educational

A private operating foundation based in the United States and/or U.S. Territories und

A U.S. tribal government treated as a State pursuant to IRC Section 7871.

An entity organized under the laws of a foreign jurisdiction which has received a tax

Affiliates of national organizations as long as the affiliate is a separate 501(c)(3)

An entity that is recognized under the law of the applicable jurisdiction as a non-go

A national, regional, or local governmental entity.

A for-profit organization, including LLCs, benefit corporations, or hybrid organizati

Individuals and entities that, from a tax perspective, have the tax status of an indi

An entity that has received a tax determination letter from the IRS under section 501

None of the above.
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This confirms that you do not need to open a foundation or have a 501(c)(3) lead: an eligible for-profit organization can lead the application directly. The readiness tool explicitly says for-profit organizations—including LLCs, benefit corporations, and hybrid organizations—are eligible.[46]

My earlier correction was mistaken. The current rules and FAQ also explicitly include for-profit leads; I should not have presented nonprofit sponsorship as necessary. [47] [48]

What this means for FTSArcade

Your next step depends on the **legal entity behind FTSArcade**, not the website or project name.

Your current structure	Implication
A qualifying for-profit company	Can potentially apply directly as Lead Organization, subject to the competition's conditions. [48]
You personally, without a separate eligible organization	Individuals cannot serve as Lead Organization. [46]
A single-member LLC treated for tax purposes as an individual	Explicitly excluded by the readiness tool; do not assume every LLC qualifies. [46]
A project with an eligible nonprofit fiscal sponsor	Also a permitted route, but not mandatory for an eligible company. [47]

There is still a geographic issue to resolve if your proposed company is based in Bulgaria: the FAQ introduces eligibility as requiring U.S. or U.S.-territory-based leads, while the rules and readiness tool contain foreign-entity categories. **Get written confirmation of your specific entity's eligibility rather than assuming a Bulgarian company qualifies.** [46] [47]

The money must serve charity

For-profit eligibility does not make this unrestricted business-development funding. Award funds must serve tax-exempt purposes, and private benefit to owners, shareholders, or other entities must be no more than incidental to accomplishing that purpose. [48]

For FTSArcade, I recommend presenting a clearly defined San Francisco public-benefit program with its own budget, beneficiaries, outcomes, and financial controls—not simply "fund our arcade company."

An ordinary commercial expansion proposal would not satisfy the requirement merely because the applicant is an eligible company. [48]

Additional compliance requirements

A for-profit award is subject to **expenditure responsibility** under IRC §4945(h), and the lead must be willing and able to comply throughout the award. [48]

For planning purposes, have a U.S. nonprofit-tax attorney and accountant help you prepare:

- A documented charitable purpose and permitted-use budget
- Project-specific accounting and spending controls
- Financial and outcome reporting procedures
- Policies for owner compensation, related-party transactions, and IP licensing
- Procedures to identify and prevent prohibited spending

These are recommended preparation steps, not a substitute for the grant agreement or legal advice.

What to do now

Do not create a foundation solely to solve a requirement this competition does not impose.

First establish:

1. Which legal entity owns or operates FTSArcade?
2. Where is it incorporated and based?
3. What is its tax classification?
4. Which entity, if any, registered before the deadline?

Then request written eligibility confirmation at boundless-sf@submittable.com, the contact listed in the rules.[48]

Is FTSArcade currently operated by you personally, a Bulgarian company, or a U.S. company?

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Evaluation Process
About the Evaluation Rubric
The Boundless San Francisco Evaluation Rubric, below, will be used to assess applications during Participatory Review and during Evaluation Panel Review. During Participatory Review, each valid application will be reviewed by at least four (4) peer Applicants who will assess each application on the four criteria that comprise the Evaluation Rubric. Once Participatory Review is complete, top Applicants will advance to the Evaluation Panel, where they will be reviewed by at least four (4) Evaluation Panel Reviewers who will use the same Evaluation Rubric to assess each application.

The rubric is built upon four distinct criteria, guiding reviewers to consider each trait in isolation when evaluating applications. In both stages of review, reviewers will assign a score for each of the four criteria and provide a comment to justify each decision. Those scores and comments will be compiled into one composite assessment of each application, and each Applicant will receive its “package” of scores/comments from the assigned reviewers (who will be anonymous to the Applicants).

This process is designed to be transparent, fair, and open while providing a value-added experience for Applicants. Even Applicants who do not receive an award will receive feedback from peers and many will receive feedback from Evaluation Panel Reviewers about their applications.

The Evaluation Rubric includes four criteria that are equally weighted across a five-point scale. Each Applicant can receive between 1 and 5 points on each scale, representing a total possible
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scoring range between 5-20 from each reviewer. When reviewing the rubric, there are different descriptors within each scale. They are:

Trait: The name attributed to each review criterion (e.g., “Durability”).
Prompt: One or more questions, intended to clarify areas of consideration when defining a Trait.
Evaluation Range Definitions: Clarifying statements to define sub-scoring ranges (e.g., 2 vs. a 4).
With four (4) reviews per application, the total maximum score from the four assigned reviewers for each trait is 20, and the maximum aggregate total score is 80 points.

Download Evaluation Rubric

Evaluation Rubric
Reducing Bias in the Evaluation Process
#1 TRANSFORMATIVE AMBITION
Will this approach meaningfully shift conditions for San Franciscans? Will the solution go beyond delivering services by changing systems, policies, norms, or opportunity structures? Is the theory of change bold, coherent, and proportionate to the resources requested?
INCREMENTAL

1: Does not demonstrate potential to shift conditions for San Franciscans. It focuses exclusively on service delivery without engaging the systems, policies, norms, or opportunity structures that sustain the problem. The theory of change is absent, unclear, or not proportionate to the resources requested.

2: Shows limited potential to shift conditions for San Franciscans beyond direct service delivery. It references broader change but does not articulate a credible path toward it. The theory of change is underdeveloped or only loosely proportionate to the resources requested.

3: Demonstrates some potential to shift conditions for San Franciscans by moving beyond service delivery to engage systems, policies, norms, or opportunity structures that contribute to the problem. The theory of change is coherent and generally proportionate to the resources requested.

4: Presents strong potential to shift conditions for San Franciscans by clearly targeting systems, policies, norms, or opportunity structures that sustain the problem. The theory of change is bold, coherent, and well-proportionate to the resources requested. Where service delivery is present, it serves as a foundation for that broader structural ambition rather than an end in itself.

5: Offers exceptional potential to fundamentally shift conditions for San Franciscans by targeting systems, policies, norms, or opportunity structures that sustain the problem at scale. The theory of change is bold, rigorous, and compellingly proportionate to the resources requested. Any direct service work is explicitly connected to and in service of that structural ambition.

TRANSFORMATIVE

#2 VIABILITY
Does the proposal demonstrate a credible and specific plan for achieving results in San Francisco? Does the team have an understanding of the city's context, the communities to be served, and the partnerships, relationships, or strategies needed to execute here? For organizations without an existing San Francisco presence, is there a realistic and well-reasoned path to establishing that presence?
IMPLAUSIBLE

1: Lacks a credible plan for achieving results in San Francisco. It shows little to no understanding of the city's context, the communities to be served, or the partnerships, relationships, and strategies needed to execute. Where applicable, applicants without an existing San Francisco presence offer no realistic path to establishing one.

2: Shows limited evidence of a credible plan for achieving results in San Francisco. Understanding of the city's context and the communities to be served is surface-level. Partnerships, relationships, or strategies described are vague and insufficient for successful implementation. Where applicable, applicants without an existing San Francisco presence offer a weak or unconvincing path to establishing one.

3: Offers a credible plan for achieving results in San Francisco. Demonstrates a working understanding of the city's context and the communities to be served. Partnerships, relationships, or strategies are adequately identified and suggest the team has a reasonable foundation for successful implementation. Where applicable, applicants without an existing San Francisco presence offer a plausible path to establishing one.

4: Presents a strong and specific plan for achieving results in San Francisco. Reflects a clear understanding of the city's context and the communities to be served. Partnerships, relationships, or strategies are well-defined and clearly positioned to support successful implementation. Where applicable, applicants without an existing San Francisco presence offer a realistic and well-reasoned path to establishing one.

5: Offers an exceptional and detailed plan for achieving results in San Francisco. Demonstrates deep understanding of the city's context and the communities to be served. Partnerships, relationships, or strategies are concrete and constitute a significant asset for successful implementation. Where applicable, applicants without an existing San Francisco presence offer a compelling and thoroughly reasoned path to establishing one.

COMPELLING

#3 EVIDENCE OF RESULTS
Is there compelling evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that this approach works or is working? For early-stage applicants, is the theory of change grounded in a well-reasoned logic and relevant analogous evidence, even if direct results data is limited?
UNSUBSTANTIATED

1: Provides no meaningful evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that the approach works. For established applicants, there are no results to speak of. For early-stage applicants, the theory of change is poorly reasoned and draws on no relevant analogous evidence.

2: Provides weak evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that the approach works. For established applicants, results are limited. For early-stage applicants, the theory of change is underdeveloped and loosely connected to relevant analogous evidence.

3: Provides adequate evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that the approach works. For established applicants, results are present but not compelling. For early-stage applicants, the theory of change is sound and grounded in relevant analogous evidence, even if direct results data is limited.

4: Provides strong evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that the approach works. For established applicants, results are clearly documented and speak to the effectiveness of the approach. For early-stage applicants, the theory of change is well-reasoned and supported by meaningful analogous evidence.

5: Provides compelling evidence (quantitative or qualitative, internal or external) that the approach works. For established applicants, results are robust, well-documented, and directly relevant. For early-stage applicants, the theory of change is rigorous and supported by strong analogous evidence that makes a persuasive case for the proposed approach.

WELL-EVIDENCED

#4 DURABILITY
Will this work generate lasting benefits beyond the grant period? Does the proposal demonstrate a credible vision for how results will be sustained—whether through financial sustainability, policy change, institutional adoption, community ownership, or other mechanisms? Does the organization have a realistic plan for the five-year horizon and beyond?
FLEETING

1: Lacks a credible vision for sustaining results beyond the grant period. There is no meaningful plan for financial sustainability, policy change, institutional adoption, community ownership, or other sustaining mechanisms. There is no articulation of what lasting benefit looks like for the people or systems served. No realistic plan for the five-year horizon and beyond.

2: Offers limited evidence of a credible vision for sustaining results beyond the grant period. Plans for sustainability are vague or rely on assumptions that are not well-supported. The plan for the five-year horizon and beyond is underdeveloped.

3: Demonstrates a vision for sustaining results beyond the grant period. Identifies plausible mechanisms for sustainability, whether financial, policy-related, institutional, or community-based, though the plan for the five-year horizon and beyond could be more fully developed.

4: Presents a strong and credible vision for sustaining results beyond the grant period. It articulates clear mechanisms for sustainability, whether financial, policy-related, institutional, or community-based, and offers a realistic picture of the lasting benefits those mechanisms are designed to protect. Offers a realistic plan for the five-year horizon and beyond.

5: Outlines an exceptional and well-substantiated vision for sustaining results well beyond the grant period. Demonstrates a comprehensive approach to sustainability through multiple

reinforcing mechanisms and offers a compelling articulation of the lasting benefits those mechanisms are designed to protect. The proposal offers a thorough, realistic plan for the five-year horizon and beyond.

LASTING

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**This rubric tells us that FTSArcade needs to be the enabling technology for a credi

My recommendation is to design the project against those four tests **before** writin

## What this changes

A proposal to "build more games and make them freely available" would leave importan

Those are central to the rubric, including whether the ambition is proportionate to

Use this as your planning matrix:

| Criterion | Question your team must answer | Recommended supporting material |
|---|---|---|
| Transformative ambition | What barrier or opportunity structure changes—not simply
| Viability | Who delivers the program in San Francisco, and how? | Local delivery pl
| Evidence of results | Why should reviewers believe this approach produces the inter
| Durability | What benefits and delivery capacity remain after the grant? | Long-ter

These questions translate the official criteria into a preparation checklist; the sug

## Choose a defensible intervention

One **possible** direction—not a claim about what FTSArcade already achieves—is a San

> Use accessible games as an entry point into supported game creation, paid practical

In that design, the arcade attracts participation; facilitated learning and paid oppo

But **only choose this direction if your team can actually deliver it**. Do not add w

Before committing, establish:

- **Population:** Which San Franciscans, with what unmet need?
- **Barrier:** Cost, equipment access, lack of mentoring, unpaid entry pathways, or s
- **Intervention:** What precisely addresses that barrier?
- **Delivery:** Who provides instruction, support, and opportunities?
- **Outcome:** What changes beyond participation and gameplay?
- **Alternative:** Why this approach instead of an existing program?

## Write the causal chain
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I would draft a one-page theory of change using this structure:

**Documented barrier → program activity → immediate output → participant outcome → la

For the hypothetical pathway above:

Element	Illustrative content—not established results
Barrier	Participants face a verified obstacle to accessing creative-technology tr
Activity	Local partners deliver supported game-building projects and paid practic
Output	Participants complete projects and receive instruction and mentoring
Outcome	Participants demonstrate skills and progress into paid work or further ed
Lasting change	Institutions maintain accessible entry pathways beyond the grant

Every arrow is an assumption you must explain and support. For example, completing a

Build an honest evidence case

Early-stage applicants are not automatically ruled out. The rubric allows a rigor

Separate your evidence into three categories:

- **Product evidence:** Does the platform function reliably and accessibly?
- **Delivery evidence:** Can your team recruit, support, and retain the intended par
- **Outcome evidence:** Does the intervention produce the claimed learning, employmer

Website traffic and repeat play may support engagement claims. I would not present th

For external evidence, record the studied population, intervention, outcomes, and di

Make local execution concrete

An organization without an existing San Francisco presence can still score well, but

For your internal delivery plan, specify:

- Local program leadership and decision-making
- Confirmed versus prospective partners
- Recruitment channels and participant eligibility
- Locations, equipment, accessibility, and support needs
- Staffing and safeguarding responsibilities
- Implementation dependencies and fallback plans
- Community input that will shape the program

**Naming organizations you hope to approach is not the same as securing delivery capa

Make $50 million proportionate

The rubric explicitly tests whether the theory of change is proportionate to the reso

My recommendation is to build a bottom-up budget and ask:

1. What outcomes are realistically achievable?
1. What delivery scale is needed to achieve them?
1. What does that scale cost?

```
1. What portion is technology versus community delivery?
1. What happens if recruitment, adoption, or outcomes fall short?
1. What annual operating costs remain after the grant?

A $50 million request should emerge from that analysis. If the credible program costs

For durability, identify who maintains the technology, pays ongoing costs, retains pr

## Run a mock review

Have independent readers score each criterion from 1 to 5 and explain their reasoning

Ask each reader to identify:

- The strongest substantiated claim
- The most important unsupported assumption
- The main execution risk
- What would justify the next higher score

Also note a small arithmetic inconsistency in the published text: four criteria score

**The next useful step is a two-page project concept—not a full grant narrative.** I



<div align="center">⁂</div>

[^5_1]: https://boundless-sf.leverforchange.org/evaluationprocess

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# ```
Lever for Change addresses possible biases in the evaluation process both on the fron

On the front end, Lever for Change's Participatory Review and Evaluation Panel Review

Lever for Change also works to address unconscious bias inherent in the evaluation pr

During both Participatory Review and Evaluation Panel Review, each reviewer only revi

Normalization relies on finding the mean score given for all applications and the mea

The evaluation and normalization process will be conducted at two points during the C

As a further risk mitigation step, Lever for Change staff review reviewers' scores ar

If at any point in the process, it is determined that an applicant does not meet the
```

This means we should make FTSArcade easy to assess against the rubric—not try to optimize for generous reviewers. Lever for Change adjusts scores to account for differences in reviewer scoring tendencies, separately after peer review and expert-panel review.[49]

What normalization means

A high raw score is not necessarily your final comparative result: scores from unusually generous reviewers are adjusted downward, while scores from unusually strict reviewers are adjusted upward.[49]

The explanation does **not** specify the exact formula, advancement cutoff, or number of applications advancing, so we cannot reliably calculate your odds from a hypothetical score. Normalization addresses scoring tendencies; it does not guarantee that every misunderstanding or bias disappears.[49]

How we should prepare

My recommendation is to make every important claim **clear, supported, and connected to a scoring criterion.**

Criterion	How to reduce reviewer uncertainty
Transformative ambition	Identify the specific condition you will change and explain why the intervention goes beyond providing games
Viability	State who delivers what in San Francisco, with timelines, costs, responsibilities, and accurately described partnerships
Evidence of results	Separate demonstrated results, analogous research, and assumptions still to be tested
Durability	Explain who maintains the program, funds ongoing operations, and protects benefits after the grant

These preparation recommendations correspond to the four equally weighted criteria.[49]

For FTSArcade specifically, I would avoid making reviewers infer the public benefit from the website. The application should explain the complete intervention in plain language, including what happens **beyond playing the games.**

Test comprehension before scoring

Run a mock review with readers who do not already know the project. Before asking them for scores, ask them to answer:

1. Who in San Francisco benefits?
2. What problem does the project address?
3. What does the team actually deliver?
4. Why should that produce the claimed outcomes?
5. Why is the requested amount justified?
6. What remains after funding ends?

If their answers differ substantially, revise the proposal before polishing its language. Then ask each reader to score the four criteria independently and explain what evidence would justify a higher score.

Do not normalize your small mock-review sample to predict the official result. Use disagreements to find unclear claims and weak assumptions instead.

Eligibility remains a separate gate

Strong scores cannot rescue an ineligible application: the published process permits disqualification whenever an eligibility failure is identified.[49]

Keep two separate internal checklists:

- **Eligibility:** Legal lead, registration, permitted organizational structure, required approvals, and grant-use compliance
- **Competitiveness:** Local relevance, credible execution, evidence, proportionate budget, and lasting benefits

The next document to build is a rubric-to-evidence matrix: one row for each major claim, its supporting evidence, the relevant criterion, and any unresolved gap. That will be more useful now than writing a promotional description of the arcade.

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do we need an entry vehicle

You need one eligible legal entity to serve as the Lead Organization, but not necessarily a new U.S. company or foundation. The competition requires a single legal entity with actual legal and operational control over the project and any award funds.[50] [51]

What can serve as the lead

Structure	Can it lead?	Notes
Qualifying U.S. for-profit company	**Yes**	Award funds are subject to expenditure-responsibility requirements. [51]
Qualifying U.S. nonprofit or fiscal sponsor	**Yes**	A sponsor must control the funds and project. [50]
Qualifying foreign entity	**Potentially**	The rules and FAQ contain categories for foreign organizations, but their wording creates geographic ambiguity. [51] [50]
You personally	**No**	Individuals cannot lead. [52]
Single-member LLC treated as an individual	**No**	Explicitly excluded. [52]

An ineligible person or company can still participate as a contractor or subgrantee selected by an eligible lead.[51]

My recommendation

Do not create an entity solely because the application needs one. First determine whether an existing eligible organization can lead.

Your practical choices are:

1. **Use an existing eligible company or nonprofit** that will genuinely control the project.
2. **Partner with an eligible nonprofit fiscal sponsor** if you do not have an eligible organization.
3. **Create a new entity only if necessary**, after confirming its structure, location, and tax treatment with U.S. nonprofit counsel and an accountant.

Creating a shell company would not solve the underlying requirements. The lead must control spending, supervise implementation, and report on results. Award funds must serve charitable purposes, with only incidental private benefit. [51]

Geographic issue to resolve

The FAQ says eligible leads must be based in the United States or its territories, but the rules also include certain foreign-entity categories. A Bulgarian individual or company therefore should not assume it can lead without written confirmation. [50] [51]

Before incorporating anything, ask the competition:

> "Can our specific existing entity, organized in [jurisdiction] and based in [location], serve as Lead Organization? If not, would a newly formed U.S. subsidiary or a U.S. fiscal sponsor be eligible, and what approvals are required before submission?"

What legal entity currently owns FTSArcade, and where is it organized and based? That determines whether you need a new entry vehicle or only a documented relationship with an existing eligible lead.

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we need a prospectus

No—the investment prospectus is not the document due now. It is the comprehensive proposal finalists develop after selection and submit in August 2027; the immediate requirement is the Stage 1 application, due October 15, 2026, at 5 p.m. Pacific Time. [53] [54]

My recommendation is to draft an internal prospectus-style packet now, then condense it into the actual application. That gives you the substance the prospectus will eventually require without confusing it with the current submission.

What is due now

The current process has two stages:

1. **Stage 1 application:** A registered organization submits its initial proposal. The competition estimates this requires at least 10 hours.[53]
2. **Finalist prospectus:** Three to seven finalists each receive development support, then submit an investment prospectus in August 2027. Up to three may later receive $10–50 million.[54] [53]

Only organizations that completed registration by September 11 can submit the application.[54]

The competition has not published a detailed prospectus template or required attachment list. The following structure is therefore my recommended internal working document, not an official submission format.

Build the internal prospectus

1. Executive case

Write one page covering:

- The San Francisco population and problem
- The proposed intervention and role of FTSArcade
- The structural change, not merely the service
- The funding request and expected outcomes
- What continues after the grant

2. Theory of change

Use this chain:

Documented barrier → activities → outputs → participant outcomes → lasting change

Every connection should identify its evidence or explicitly state that it is an assumption to be tested.

3. San Francisco delivery plan

Include:

- Local leadership and responsibilities
- Confirmed versus prospective partners
- Recruitment, locations, accessibility, and participant support
- Implementation phases and decision points
- Risks and fallback plans

An organization without an existing San Francisco presence must explain a realistic route to establishing one. [53]

4. Evidence register

Separate:

- What FTSArcade has already demonstrated
- Relevant external or analogous evidence
- Assumptions without direct evidence
- How those gaps will be tested

Early-stage applicants may rely on a rigorous theory of change and relevant analogous evidence when direct results are limited. [53]

5. Five-year financial model

Build the budget from delivery assumptions rather than starting at $50 million. Include staffing, community delivery, technology, evaluation, administration, and ongoing operating costs.

If below-market financing is genuinely necessary, you may request a Program-Related Investment alongside grant funding. The amount must reflect actual need, and approval is discretionary. [53]

6. Durability and governance

Explain:

- Who legally controls the project and funds
- How spending serves the charitable purpose
- Who owns or licenses the technology
- Who pays operating costs after the grant
- What benefits remain if your company changes or exits

Financial statements are not required in this first stage, but later stages may require at least two years of statements and organizational-health materials. [55]

Translate it into the application

Once the internal packet exists, answer the portal questions directly. Do not submit the full internal prospectus unless the form requests it.

Use the packet to ensure every answer addresses:

- **Transformative ambition**
- **Viability**

- **Evidence of results**
- **Durability**

Those are the four equally weighted criteria. [53]

The immediate deliverable should be a 6–10 page internal concept and budget workbook, followed by a portal-ready application. A polished 30-page prospectus would consume time better spent answering the actual form and resolving eligibility.

Do you already have the application questions from your registered Submittable account? If so, I can turn this prospectus structure into responses matched to those exact questions.

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exactly, let's formalize the methodology for writing so

The methodology is to build one evidence-backed project case first, then derive both the internal prospectus and the Stage 1 application from it. Do not write promotional prose before the project logic, evidence, budget, and eligibility are settled.

The official application questions are not publicly published, so this is an internal writing system rather than a guaranteed portal template. The application must be in English, complete, and submitted through the registered account by October 15, 2026, at 5 p.m. Pacific Time. [60] [61]

Writing principles

1. **Write one claim at a time.** Every sentence should make a factual, causal, or proposed claim that can be checked.
2. **Label certainty.** Use “demonstrated,” “supported by analogous evidence,” or “proposed assumption.” Never blend them.
3. **Lead with the public benefit.** Introduce FTSArcade only after defining who benefits and what changes.
4. **Match the four criteria.** Each major section must support transformative ambition, viability, evidence, or durability. [62]
5. **Write for an unfamiliar reviewer.** A peer reviewer may know neither games nor your organization. [62]
6. **Keep the requested funding proportionate.** Do not begin with $50 million and reverse-engineer activities.
7. **Separate legal control from delivery roles.** The Lead Organization must actually control funds and implementation. [60]

Build the source case

Create one master document before drafting narrative text. Every later prospectus or application paragraph must trace back to it.

Source section	Required content	Completion test
Beneficiary	Specific San Francisco population	A reviewer can identify who is included and excluded
Problem	Current condition and its cause	Supported by a source or documented observation
Intervention	Activities, dose, setting, and duration	Someone else could understand what happens
Platform role	What FTSArcade uniquely contributes	Its function is narrower than “the whole project”
Theory of change	Barrier, activity, output, outcome, lasting change	Every arrow has evidence or an explicit assumption
Delivery	People, partners, locations, timeline, dependencies	Responsibilities are assigned
Evidence	Direct results, analogous evidence, gaps	No unsupported effectiveness claim remains
Budget	Quantities, unit costs, timing, assumptions	Costs come from the delivery plan
Durability	Post-grant owner, funding, access, maintenance	Benefits do not depend only on continued grant funding
Eligibility	Lead entity, authority, charitable use, rights	A named person can verify each item

Use a fixed paragraph method

For every substantive paragraph, follow this sequence:

1. **State the claim.**
2. **Give the most relevant fact or mechanism.**
3. **Explain why it matters to San Francisco.**
4. **Identify the evidence, limitation, or implementation condition.**
5. **Connect it to the next action or outcome.**

A strong paragraph answers “what, why, how, and on what basis” without adding slogans.

Use this internal drafting formula:

> For [defined beneficiaries], [named barrier] limits [specific opportunity]. The project will [specific activity], delivered by [responsible party], so that [measurable result] occurs. This is expected to contribute to [broader change] because [evidence or reasoned mechanism]. [Named party] will sustain [specific element] after the grant through [mechanism].

Delete any clause that cannot be supported or assigned to someone.

Draft in this order

1. Define the intervention

Write a half-page description containing:

- Who participates
- What they receive
- How often and for how long
- Where it happens
- Who delivers it
- What FTSArcade does
- What success looks like after one year

If this cannot be written clearly, the prospectus is not ready.

2. Build the theory of change

Create one row per causal link:

Link	Statement	Basis	Risk if wrong
Problem to activity	Why this activity addresses the barrier	Evidence or assumption	Activity may not matter
Activity to output	What the activity produces	Delivery plan	Output may not occur
Output to outcome	Why the output changes participants' conditions	Evidence or assumption	Outcome may not follow
Outcome to system change	How individual results alter a broader structure	Evidence or assumption	Change remains small or temporary

Do not claim system change merely because many people receive a service. Explain the institutional, policy, economic, or opportunity-structure mechanism.

3. Construct the evidence register

Assign every material claim one status:

- **Demonstrated:** Your team has relevant data.
- **Analogous:** External evidence supports a similar mechanism, with differences disclosed.
- **Assumed:** Plausible but untested; include how and when it will be tested.
- **Removed:** Cannot be supported and is not necessary.

Early-stage applicants may rely on a well-reasoned theory of change and analogous evidence, but weak or absent evidence receives a lower score.[62]

4. Build the budget from operations

For each activity, specify quantity, frequency, staffing, partner cost, participant support, technology, evaluation, and administration. Then calculate the total.

Only after that should you test whether the request should be $10 million, $50 million, or another amount within the published award range.[62]

5. Write the narrative last

Draft the internal prospectus in this order:

1. Problem and beneficiaries
2. Intervention
3. Why it changes conditions
4. San Francisco implementation
5. Evidence and evaluation
6. Budget and proportionality
7. Five-year and post-grant durability
8. Governance, rights, and risk

Each section should be understandable independently because application questions may split the material differently.

Convert it into the application

Once the portal questions are available, make a conversion matrix:

Application question	Source sections used	Rubric criteria served	Word limit	Unsupported items removed
[Paste exact question]	[Section numbers]	[Relevant criteria]	[Portal limit]	[Claims cut]

Answer the question directly in the first sentence. Do not begin with organizational history unless the question asks for it.

Then cut in this order:

1. Repeated context
2. Adjectives that make no factual difference
3. Activities not funded or scheduled
4. Claims without evidence
5. Technical detail a reviewer does not need

Review before submission

Use three separate reviews:

- **Comprehension review:** An unfamiliar reader explains the project without looking back at the draft.
- **Rubric review:** Four readers independently score all four criteria and identify what prevents a higher score. [62]
- **Evidence review:** Another person checks every factual, partnership, budget, legal, and outcome claim against the source case.

A section passes only when the reviewer can identify the beneficiary, action, responsible party, evidence basis, and limitation without inference.

Operating rules for the writing team

- One person owns the source case; others propose changes rather than creating competing versions.
- No new promise enters the narrative unless it is added to the delivery plan, budget, and evidence register.
- Partnership language must say “confirmed,” “in discussion,” or “proposed.”
- Product metrics such as visits or gameplay cannot be relabeled as learning or employment outcomes.
- The Lead Organization’s authority must be described accurately, especially if a sponsor or partner is involved. [60]
- Everything submitted must be in English. [60]

The immediate deliverable is the source-case table, not prose. Once that is complete, the internal prospectus can be drafted in one pass and then condensed to the portal questions.

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The methodology needs a second layer: a claim-control system, section templates, and editing tests that keep the prospectus internally consistent. The goal is to make every sentence traceable to a beneficiary, activity, owner, cost, and evidence status before anyone edits for style.

Claim ledger

Assign every material statement an ID before using it in prose. No prospectus sentence should introduce a claim that is absent from this ledger.

ID	Claim	Type	Evidence status	Owner	Budget link	Rubric link	Permitted wording
C1	Who benefits	Factual	Source required	Program lead	Participant costs	Ambition, viability	Name the population precisely
C2	What barrier exists	Factual	Source or documented observation	Research lead	None	Ambition	State scope and limitation
C3	What activity occurs	Operational	Delivery plan	Delivery lead	Activity budget	Viability	State dose, setting, duration
C4	Why activity changes outcome	Causal	Evidence or explicit assumption	Evaluation lead	Evaluation budget	Evidence	Distinguish support from assumption
C5	What remains after funding	Forward-looking	Sustainability plan	Executive owner	Post-grant budget	Durability	Identify mechanism and responsible party

Use four claim types only:

- **Factual:** Something currently observable or documented.
- **Operational:** Something the project will do.
- **Causal:** Why an activity should produce a result.
- **Forward-looking:** What is expected to continue or change later.

This prevents a sentence such as “the arcade empowers youth” from entering the draft. It has no defined population, mechanism, evidence status, owner, or measurable result.

Evidence grading

Every causal claim needs a grade before drafting.

Grade	Meaning	Permitted treatment
E1	Direct evidence from this project and population	State as demonstrated, with metric and limitation
E2	Direct evidence from a closely comparable program	State similarity and relevant differences
E3	Relevant analogous evidence	Use to support the mechanism, not identical outcomes
E4	Plausible but untested assumption	Label as an assumption and include a test
E5	Insufficient support	Remove from the prospectus

A sentence may move down in confidence, but never up. For example, an E3 finding cannot be rewritten as “proven.” If removing an E5 claim damages the project logic, the project design—not the prose—needs revision.

Section templates

Write each section to a fixed job. A section fails if it tries to accomplish another section's job.

Problem

Include:

- Beneficiary definition
- Current condition
- Scale within San Francisco
- Cause or maintaining barrier
- Consequence of inaction
- Source and limitation

Exclude the solution. If the problem cannot stand independently, the intervention is probably shaping the evidence rather than responding to it.

Intervention

Specify:

- Participant pathway from recruitment through completion
- Frequency, duration, and setting
- Responsible organization for each step
- What portion is facilitated by people rather than software
- What FTSArcade contributes
- What happens when a participant misses sessions or lacks equipment

A reviewer should be able to reconstruct the participant experience chronologically.

Structural change

Answer:

- Which system, policy, norm, resource, or opportunity structure changes
- Who controls that structure now
- What leverage the project has over it
- Why individual outcomes accumulate into a broader change
- What result would remain even if one cohort ended

If the only result is that participants received a service, classify it as service delivery and revise the structural claim.

Delivery

Use one implementation row per workstream:

Workstream	Output	Responsible party	Dependencies	Start condition	Failure response
Recruitment	Eligible participants enrolled	Named organization	Access to population	Agreement and staffing	Alternative channel or reduced cohort
Program delivery	Sessions completed	Named team	Facilitators and facilities	Training complete	Pause cohort; do not expand
Platform	Required functions available	Named technical owner	Licensing and maintenance	Acceptance test passed	Use manual fallback or delay launch
Evaluation	Usable outcome data	Named evaluator	Consent and instruments	Baseline defined	Correct method before scaling

“Proposed,” “in discussion,” and “confirmed” must remain visible in this table and in any prose derived from it.

Budget narrative

For every major cost, follow this sequence:

1. Name the operating assumption.
2. Show the quantity and unit cost.
3. Connect it to an output.
4. State what happens if the assumption changes.
5. Identify any cost that continues after the grant.

Do not use percentages alone. “Twenty percent for technology” is not an explanation unless the underlying activities and costs are shown.

Decision gates

The writing process should stop at defined gates rather than proceeding automatically to prose.

Gate	Required condition	If unmet
Beneficiary gate	Population, need, and geography are defined	Do not draft the problem
Mechanism gate	Every causal arrow is E1–E4	Remove or redesign unsupported links
Delivery gate	Each activity has an owner and dependency	Do not claim viability
Budget gate	Request equals supported costs	Resize project or request
Eligibility gate	Lead has authority and can lawfully control funds	Resolve structure before submission
Translation gate	Every portal answer maps to source claims	Do not submit narrative-only text

A missed gate cannot be repaired with stronger adjectives, design language, or a longer vision statement.

Editing tests

Run these tests after the first complete draft:

- **Deletion test:** Remove FTSArcade from the paragraph. If no intelligible intervention remains, the project is underdefined.
- **Substitution test:** Replace the beneficiary with a different city. If no San Francisco-specific facts remain, viability is too generic.
- **Owner test:** Underline every action. Any action without a responsible party is not yet operational.
- **Evidence test:** Underline every causal verb, such as “improves,” “leads to,” or “enables.” Each must point to an evidence grade.
- **Budget test:** Underline every promised output. Each must have a cost or an explicit zero-cost explanation.
- **Durability test:** End the grant on paper. Identify which activities, jobs, maintenance, and participant benefits survive.
- **Proportionality test:** Reduce the request by half. State exactly which outputs disappear and why the original request is consequently justified.
- **Adversarial test:** A reviewer challenges the weakest assumption. The draft should acknowledge and test it before the reviewer discovers it.

Version control

Use three documents only:

1. **Source case:** Claims, evidence, operations, and costs. This is authoritative.
2. **Internal prospectus:** Long-form explanation derived from the source case.
3. **Application answers:** Portal-specific responses derived from the prospectus.

Changes flow downstream only. If application editing reveals a better idea, add it to the source case first and then revise the prospectus. This prevents unsupported promises from appearing spontaneously in the final answers.

Each version should carry:

- Date and author
- Claims added or retired
- Budget version
- Partnership-status changes
- Unresolved eligibility questions

Review roles

Separate writing authority from approval authority.

Role	Responsibility	Cannot do
Source owner	Maintains claims and consistency	Invent evidence
Program lead	Validates intervention and delivery	Expand scope without budget changes
Evidence reviewer	Grades claims and identifies limits	Rewrite weaknesses as facts
Budget owner	Ties costs to activities	Add narrative commitments
Independent reader	Tests clarity and scoring	Repair gaps through interpretation
Authorized signatory	Approves final submission	Submit unresolved eligibility claims

At least one reviewer should be unfamiliar with games and one unfamiliar with the organization. Their misunderstandings are drafting defects, not reviewer failures.

Final compression

When converting the prospectus into application answers, compress in this order:

1. Preserve beneficiary, intervention, mechanism, evidence, cost, and owner.
2. Remove background that the question does not request.
3. Replace broad verbs with operational verbs.
4. Cut claims graded E5.
5. Reduce repeated justification.
6. Check that the answer still makes sense without adjacent answers.

The finished answer should begin with the conclusion, follow with the mechanism, and end with the condition or limitation. Style editing comes only after this sequence.

The next practical step is to create the claim ledger with roughly 15–25 claims. Once those claims are graded and assigned owners, the prospectus can be assembled without reopening the project concept in every paragraph.

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The next layer is a production system: define the analytical work products, set the standard of proof for each, and use explicit rules for converting analysis into prospectus language. This keeps the document from growing while unresolved questions remain.

Work products

Create the prospectus from completed work products, not from a blank narrative outline.

Work product	Core question	Minimum acceptable content	Blocks prospectus if missing
Beneficiary definition	Who is served?	Inclusion rules, exclusion rules, geography, estimated reachable population	Yes
Problem analysis	What condition will change?	Baseline, cause, consequence, source, limitation	Yes
Intervention specification	What exactly happens?	Pathway, dose, setting, staffing, completion point	Yes
Platform specification	What does FTSArcade contribute?	Functions used, users, dependencies, fallback	Yes
Theory of change	Why should results follow?	Causal links, assumptions, evidence grades	Yes
Delivery map	Who executes?	Responsibilities, sequence, dependencies, partner status	Yes
Measurement plan	How will results be known?	Indicators, data source, timing, responsible party	Yes
Cost model	What funding is justified?	Quantities, unit costs, timing, sensitivity	Yes
Durability model	What survives the grant?	Owner, operating cost, revenue or adoption mechanism	Yes
Risk register	What could invalidate the plan?	Risk, likelihood, consequence, mitigation, residual risk	No, but weak viability
Rights schedule	Can the lead use the assets?	Owner, license, restrictions, third-party rights	Yes before submission

Each work product needs an owner and a status: draft, reviewed, or approved. Approved means accepted for use in prose, not necessarily perfect.

Standards of proof

Use different standards for different kinds of statements.

Statement type	Required support	Unacceptable support
Population need	Current source, local observation, or documented partner data	National statistic presented as a local fact
Organizational capacity	Named people, relevant experience, available time	General confidence in the team
Partnership	Written confirmation or accurately labeled discussion	Logo, informal enthusiasm, or planned outreach

Statement type	Required support	Unacceptable support
Outcome	Relevant evidence or an explicitly testable assumption	Engagement metrics substituted for outcomes
Cost	Supplier estimate, historical cost, or stated planning assumption	Round percentage without quantity
Structural change	Mechanism showing who changes what	Large participant count alone
Sustainability	Named payer, adopter, or operating model	Intention to seek future funding without a pathway

Where support is incomplete, narrow the statement. “We will test whether facilitated game-building improves completion of creative projects” is admissible as a plan; “the platform transforms employment outcomes” is not admissible without evidence.

Prospectus architecture

Use the internal prospectus as a decision document. Each section should enable a reviewer to make one judgment.

1. **Decision summary:** Beneficiary, intervention, change sought, request, and result.
2. **Need:** Condition, scale, cause, and consequence.
3. **Solution:** Participant pathway and platform function.
4. **Change mechanism:** Why outputs become outcomes and broader change.
5. **San Francisco execution:** Sequence, partners, capacity, and establishment plan.
6. **Evidence:** What is known, analogous, assumed, and untested.
7. **Measurement:** What will be collected and what decision it supports.
8. **Financial plan:** Costs, request, contingencies, and proportionality.
9. **Durability:** Five-year operation and post-grant continuation.
10. **Governance and risk:** Authority, controls, rights, and failure responses.

The summary should be written last, using only claims already accepted in the other sections.

Conversion rules

Apply these rules when turning tables into prose:

- One paragraph may contain no more than one causal chain.
- Every number must appear in the source case with its definition and period.
- A partner may be named only with its current relationship status.
- A platform feature may be included only if a participant or staff member uses it.
- A risk must be matched to a design choice, contingency, or evaluation question.
- A budget figure must be traceable to an activity quantity.

- A post-grant benefit must have an owner other than “the community” unless a specific community body is defined.
- Any sentence that could describe an unrelated project without alteration is too generic and must be revised.

Measurement design

Define indicators before claiming outcomes.

Level	Example question	Suitable indicator	Not sufficient alone
Reach	Who actually participates?	Eligible enrollments and completion	Website visits
Delivery	Was the intervention delivered as designed?	Sessions delivered, attendance, facilitator coverage	Funds spent
Capability	What can participants do?	Pre-specified project or skill assessment	Self-reported enjoyment
Progression	What opportunity follows?	Education, paid work, or continued participation	Anecdotes without denominator
System	What structure changed?	Adopted pathway, recurring slots, changed access rules	Aspirational description

For every indicator, specify baseline, target, measurement instrument, collection timing, and decision affected. A target without a baseline can still be used, but it must be labeled as a planning target rather than a forecast based on historical performance.

Financial methodology

Build the request through four layers:

1. **Unit cost:** Cost per session, participant, site, license, or staff role.
2. **Operating volume:** Number of cohorts, sites, users, or months.
3. **Support costs:** Management, evaluation, accessibility, data, and administration required to deliver that volume.
4. **Contingency and sensitivity:** Costs affected by enrollment, facilities, staffing, or delayed adoption.

Then test three scenarios:

- **Constrained:** Essential pilot and evidence-building only.
- **Proposed:** Scale justified by delivery capacity.
- **Maximum:** Scale requiring additional confirmed capacity, not merely more money.

The selected scenario should explain why cheaper options fail and why larger options cannot yet be executed responsibly.

Risk method

Score risks by their effect on the project logic, not by general seriousness.

Risk category	Question	Example response
Demand	Will intended participants enroll?	Pilot recruitment threshold before expansion
Delivery	Can staff deliver the model?	Training and maximum caseload
Mechanism	Will activities produce outcomes?	Staged evaluation before scaling
Adoption	Will institutions continue it?	Early adoption commitments or alternative owner
Technical	Will the platform support delivery?	Acceptance criteria and non-platform fallback
Financial	Will costs exceed assumptions?	Trigger for redesign or reduced cohort size
Control	Can the lead supervise funds and partners?	Approval rights and audit trail

A risk without a decision trigger is only a description. For example, “review recruitment after three months” is operational only if it states what result causes continuation, revision, or termination.

Collaboration workflow

Use short writing cycles with locked inputs.

1. **Scope lock:** Approve beneficiary, intervention, and change claim.
2. **Evidence lock:** Grade all claims and remove unsupported ones.
3. **Operations lock:** Approve delivery map and budget quantities.
4. **Narrative draft:** One writer produces the full prospectus.
5. **Fact review:** Owners verify only their claims.
6. **Independent review:** Unfamiliar readers test comprehension and scoring.
7. **Revision:** Change source documents first, then narrative.
8. **Freeze:** No new concepts after the designated freeze point.

During narrative drafting, contributors submit changes as proposed claims rather than rewritten paragraphs. This preserves a single voice and prevents contradictory promises.

Quality thresholds

A section is ready only when all applicable answers are yes:

- Can a new reader restate it in two sentences?
- Are all numbers defined?
- Are assumptions visible?
- Does every activity have an owner?
- Does every cost have an output?

- Are San Francisco execution details specific?
- Could the claim survive scrutiny without oral explanation?
- Does the section answer its assigned question without repetition?

If fewer than all applicable answers are yes, continue analysis rather than polishing language.

Production schedule

For a complete internal prospectus, use this sequence:

- **Days 1–2:** Beneficiary, problem, intervention, and platform role.
- **Days 3–4:** Theory of change, evidence grades, and measurement.
- **Days 5–6:** Delivery map, partners, and risk triggers.
- **Day 7:** Cost model and scenario selection.
- **Day 8:** Narrative draft from locked sources.
- **Day 9:** Independent and adversarial reviews.
- **Day 10:** Source corrections, final prose, and application conversion.

This schedule assumes the underlying program concept already exists. If beneficiary or intervention choices remain open, restart at the scope lock rather than drafting alternative narratives in parallel.

The strongest next work product is the intervention specification. It should describe one participant's complete experience from first contact through the intended result, including who delivers each step and where FTSArcade is and is not essential. Once that is stable, the theory of change and budget can be built without circular revisions.

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The remaining layer is operational governance for the writing effort itself: how decisions are made, how uncertainty is represented, and how the team prevents the prospectus from drifting away from what can actually be delivered. This is the control system around the methodology already established.

Decision register

Every unresolved choice gets a record before drafting continues.

Decision	Options	Decision rule	Needed information	Owner	Deadline	Consequence of delay
Beneficiary	Define alternatives	Greatest demonstrated need and reachable population	Local evidence and delivery access	Program lead	Before scope lock	All downstream work pauses

Decision	Options	Decision rule	Needed information	Owner	Deadline	Consequence of delay
Lead organization	Existing entity, sponsor, or partner	Legal eligibility and actual control	Entity documents and written confirmation	Authorized officer	Before submission	Application cannot be finalized
Funding scenario	Constrained, proposed, maximum	Delivery capacity and proportionality	Cost model	Budget owner	Before narrative	Request remains unsupported
Outcome claim	Narrow or broad result	Highest claim supportable at E1–E4	Evidence register	Evidence reviewer	Before drafting	Narrative cannot assert impact

A decision is closed only when its rationale is written. Reopening it requires new evidence or a material delivery constraint, not a stylistic preference.

Uncertainty language

Use a controlled vocabulary so reviewers can distinguish plans from facts.

Situation	Use	Avoid
Established fact	“As of [date], [source] shows…”	“Everyone knows”
Team result	“In [period], the project produced…”	“Proven success”
External evidence	“Comparable evidence suggests…”	“Research proves our model”
Assumption	“The project will test whether…”	“This will inevitably”
Partnership under discussion	“The team is in discussion with…”	“Partner X will deliver”
Future action	“The lead will…”	“The community will naturally”
Target	“The planning target is…”	“The project guarantees”

This language should survive editing. A later pass may shorten it, but it may not convert uncertainty into certainty.

Number discipline

Create a data dictionary before using figures in the prospectus.

Figure	Definition	Population	Period	Source	Calculation	Limitation
Reach	People completing enrollment	Eligible San Francisco residents	Program year	Recruitment records	Count of accepted participants	Not website users
Completion	Participants meeting defined endpoint	Enrolled cohort	Cohort duration	Attendance system	Completers divided by starters	Define acceptable absence

Figure	Definition	Population	Period	Source	Calculation	Limitation
Unit cost	Direct delivery cost per completer	Completed participants	Same cohort	Budget model	Eligible costs divided by completers	State excluded overhead
Outcome	Pre-specified result	Completers or enrolled cohort	Follow-up point	Assessment or verified record	Pre-registered method	Do not change after seeing results

Every figure needs one definition. “Users,” “participants,” “young people,” and “beneficiaries” cannot be used interchangeably unless the data dictionary says they are identical.

San Francisco specificity

A local execution claim should identify at least one of the following:

- A defined population or neighborhood
- A facility, institution, or service channel
- A local partner and its role
- A local cost condition
- A policy, procurement, or adoption pathway
- A barrier documented in San Francisco

If none can yet be named, the appropriate statement is that local presence remains to be established. The plan must then specify the sequence, responsible party, selection criteria, and decision point for establishing it.

Do not use local names decoratively. A named organization must have a role, status, and responsibility.

Platform boundary

Write a boundary statement so FTSArcade does not absorb every project function.

Include four lists:

- **Essential functions:** Functions without which the intervention cannot operate.
- **Supporting functions:** Functions that improve delivery but have a fallback.
- **Excluded functions:** Activities humans or partners must perform, such as recruitment, supervision, assessment, or pastoral support.
- **Non-claims:** Outcomes the platform is not asserted to produce by itself.

For each essential function, document its current readiness, required development, acceptance test, responsible owner, and operating cost. A feature idea without an acceptance test remains outside the prospectus.

Reviewer simulation

Have reviewers answer the prospectus in structured form rather than offering general impressions.

Reviewer prompt	Passing response
Who changes, by how much, and how will that be known?	Names population, result, and measure
What must be true for the mechanism to work?	Identifies assumptions without inventing new ones
What can be delivered in the first year?	Separates first-year capacity from eventual scale
Where is San Francisco execution dependent on others?	Names dependencies and their status
Which claim is least supported?	Matches evidence register
What cost could be removed without changing outcomes?	Identifies a real efficiency or confirms proportionality
What survives if funding stops?	Names retained asset, owner, and operating need

Reviewer comments become actions only when they identify missing information, ambiguity, or contradiction. Comments that merely request more inspiration do not justify expanding the scope.

Contradiction audit

Before freezing the prospectus, test these pairs:

- Beneficiary count matches enrollment capacity.
- Outcome claims match evidence grades.
- Partner responsibilities match partner status.
- Budget quantities match delivery volume.
- Timeline matches staffing availability.
- Evaluation measures match promised outcomes.
- Platform functions match current or funded development.
- Post-grant owner matches governance arrangements.
- Requested funds match selected scenario.
- Lead-organization authority matches legal structure.

Any contradiction is resolved in the source case first. The prospectus should then be regenerated from the corrected source rather than patched independently.

Page budget

Set a maximum length for the internal prospectus so additional analysis does not become uncontrolled prose.

Section	Maximum length	Required display
Decision summary	1 page	Beneficiary, intervention, request, result
Need and beneficiaries	2 pages	Baseline and source limitation
Intervention	2 pages	Participant pathway
Mechanism and evidence	3 pages	Causal table and evidence grades
Delivery	2 pages	Responsibility and dependency table
Measurement	1 page	Indicator table
Financial plan	2 pages plus workbook	Scenario comparison
Durability and governance	2 pages	Post-grant owner and controls
Risks	1 page	Triggers and responses

Tables count toward these limits. If a section exceeds its budget, prefer moving detail to an appendix over compressing it into ambiguous prose.

Approval packet

The final internal packet should contain:

1. Approved source case
2. Decision register
3. Data dictionary
4. Evidence register
5. Delivery and budget workbooks
6. Internal prospectus
7. Contradiction audit
8. Application-conversion matrix
9. List of unresolved questions, each with owner and deadline

The signatory approves the packet only after confirming that no unresolved question affects eligibility, budget accuracy, or a central causal claim.

Immediate production sequence

Start with these five artifacts, in order:

1. **Participant pathway:** First contact through final result.
2. **Platform boundary:** Essential, supporting, excluded, and non-claimed functions.
3. **Claim ledger:** No more than 25 claims, each graded and owned.
4. **First-year operating plan:** Only what current capacity can deliver.
5. **Unit-cost model:** Costs derived from that first-year plan.

Do not draft the full prospectus until those five agree with one another. Their agreement is the practical test that the methodology is working: the story, operations, evidence, and money describe the same project.

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The methodology can now be extended into the team's day-to-day production rules: who may change the project, how revisions are accepted, and how the final prospectus remains auditable. This is less about adding sections and more about preventing silent changes as the deadline approaches.

Change control

Any proposed edit falls into one of four classes.

Change class	Examples	Required approval	Narrative effect
Editorial	Grammar, sequence, shorter wording	Writer	None
Clarifying	Added definition, source, or limitation	Section owner	No new promise
Operational	New activity, partner, population, timeline, or cost	Program and budget owners	Update source case first
Foundational	New beneficiary, outcome, lead organization, or funding scenario	Decision owner and signatory	Reopen affected gates

An editor may not convert a clarifying change into an operational promise. For example, naming a possible San Francisco venue does not authorize the prose to say the venue is secured.

Revision record

Maintain a running record rather than relying on document comments.

Date	Proposed change	Class	Reason	Evidence affected	Budget affected	Decision	Updated documents
[Date]	Narrow outcome from employment to completed projects	Foundational	No employment evidence	Yes	Yes	Accepted	Ledger, budget, prospectus
[Date]	Add named partner	Operational	Discussion began	No	No	Accepted with "in discussion" label	Delivery map
[Date]	Replace "may" with "will"	Editorial	Requested stronger tone	No	No	Rejected	None

This record explains why the final prospectus says what it says. It also prevents deleted claims from reappearing during later compression.

Meeting protocol

Use working sessions to close decisions, not to draft collectively.

Each meeting needs:

- One decision or blockage
- The source document under review
- Options already prepared
- Information missing
- Owner and deadline for the next action

A meeting output should be a decision, a rejected option, or a defined information request. Phrases such as “explore further” require a specific question, source, responsible person, and deadline; otherwise they are not actionable.

Source hierarchy

When documents conflict, use this order:

1. Eligibility and legal constraints
2. Approved decision register
3. Budget and delivery workbook
4. Evidence register
5. Data dictionary
6. Internal prospectus
7. Application answers
8. Presentation or verbal explanation

Lower-ranked documents must be corrected to match higher-ranked ones. A polished application answer never overrides the budget or evidence register.

Traceability matrix

Every prospectus paragraph receives an identifier and trace.

Paragraph	Claim IDs	Figures	Operational dependencies	Evidence grades	Budget lines	Review status
P1	C1, C2	F1	None	E2	None	Fact-checked
P4	C3, C4	F2, F3	Partner confirmation	E4	B1	Assumption labeled
P7	C5	F4	Post-grant owner	E4	B2	Needs owner approval

Before submission, every paragraph must be fact-checked, assumption-labeled, or removed. “Needs owner approval” is not an acceptable final status.

Worked micro-example

The following illustrates the method using a hypothetical creative-technology project. It is not a proposed claim about FTSArcade and should not be copied into an application.

Source claim: Participants who attend facilitated weekly sessions will complete a small playable project.

Evidence grade: E4, testable assumption.

Operational owner: Program facilitator.

Budget link: Facilitator hours, venue, devices, and participant support.

Acceptable prose: “Each cohort will attend facilitated weekly sessions intended to result in a small playable project. Completion is a planning target, not a demonstrated outcome; the first cohorts will test whether this structure produces the expected completion rate.”

Unacceptable prose: “FTSArcade equips participants with industry-ready skills and creates transformative employment pathways.”

The unacceptable version adds skills, employment, industry readiness, and transformation without separate claims, evidence, owners, or costs.

First-year boundary

The prospectus should distinguish three horizons without blending them.

Horizon	May include	Must not include
First year	Capacity that named people and partners can deliver	Scale dependent on unsigned partners
Years two to five	Expansion triggered by stated results	Automatic growth without decision thresholds
After grant	Retained assets, adopted activities, or funded operations	Every activity continuing unchanged by default

For each expansion trigger, state the metric, threshold, review date, and person authorized to approve expansion. Growth is therefore a decision, not an assumption.

Language blacklist

Remove or rewrite these constructions unless a source explicitly supports them:

- “Revolutionary,” “world-class,” “unique,” or “cutting-edge”
- “Empower,” “unlock,” or “transform” without a defined change
- “Scalable” without a unit cost and constraint
- “Community-led” without a defined community authority
- “Sustainable” without a payer or operating model
- “Partners include” when discussions are incomplete
- “Data shows” when the source is an assumption

- “At scale” without a numerical scale
- “And more” after a list of activities
- “Solutions for San Francisco” without naming the population and condition

This is not a general style preference. These phrases conceal missing operational detail.

Final audit sequence

Conduct the audits in this order so each one uses stable inputs:

1. **Eligibility audit:** Lead, authority, geography, registration, and charitable-use constraints.
2. **Logic audit:** Beneficiary, intervention, mechanism, and outcome agree.
3. **Evidence audit:** Every causal statement has a grade and limitation.
4. **Operations audit:** Capacity, timeline, and partner status support the plan.
5. **Financial audit:** Costs, scenarios, and request agree.
6. **Traceability audit:** Every paragraph maps to claims and figures.
7. **Compression audit:** Application answers preserve meaning within portal limits.
8. **Sign-off audit:** Unresolved items cannot affect a central claim.

No audit should be combined with copyediting. Correct facts first, then shorten, then polish.

Team cadence

For the remaining preparation window, use short cycles:

- **Morning:** Update source documents and close one decision.
- **Midday:** Revise only paragraphs affected by that decision.
- **Afternoon:** Independent check of changed claims.
- **End of day:** Freeze accepted text and record rejected changes.

Limit each cycle to one foundational decision. Multiple simultaneous changes make contradictions difficult to detect and can invalidate earlier review work.

Definition of done

The methodology is complete for the current stage when:

- One participant pathway is approved.
- The platform boundary is explicit.
- Every material claim has an owner, grade, and permitted wording.
- First-year output does not exceed named capacity.
- The budget reproduces the same outputs.
- Every expansion has a trigger.
- Every prospectus paragraph is traceable.

- Application answers are derived from frozen text.
- The signatory can identify the weakest assumption without assistance from the writer.

At that point, further effort should go into verification and submission mechanics, not into generating more vision language. The prospectus is finished when its claims are controlled, not when the team stops thinking of improvements.

is this enough if I give my website + a local verson of this will it be able to draft the proposal?

No. The methodology plus the website would let a writer draft language, but not a supportable proposal. The website can describe the product; the methodology can discipline the writing. Neither supplies the decisions, evidence, local delivery plan, budget, or legal facts that the proposal must contain.

What is still missing

Required input	Why the website and method cannot replace it
Beneficiary and problem	The site does not establish who in San Francisco is served or what condition changes
Intervention	Gameplay must be connected to a specific facilitated program or other intervention
Local delivery	Needs named capacity, locations, responsibilities, and partner status
Evidence	Needs graded sources for need, mechanism, and outcomes
Budget	Needs quantities, unit costs, and a justified funding scenario
Legal lead	Needs the entity, its eligibility, authority, and registration status
Rights	Needs ownership and licensing facts for code, art, audio, and third-party components
Durability	Needs the post-grant owner, operating cost, and continuation mechanism

Without these, a model would have to invent them. That would produce a plausible-looking proposal, not a submission-ready one.

Minimum packet for a useful draft

Provide the website plus a concise source packet containing:

1. **Legal applicant:** Entity name, location, tax status, and registration status.
2. **Beneficiary:** Who is included, excluded, and where they are in San Francisco.
3. **Problem:** The condition, its cause, and sources.
4. **Participant pathway:** Each step from first contact to final result.
5. **Platform boundary:** What FTSArcade does and does not do.
6. **Delivery:** Responsible people, partner status, facilities, and first-year capacity.
7. **Evidence register:** Sources, findings, limitations, and assumptions.

8. **Budget:** Unit costs, volumes, staffing, and selected funding scenario.
9. **Durability:** Who maintains activities and pays costs after the grant.
10. **Constraints:** Claims that must not be made.

With that packet, a writer can produce a structured first draft. It will still require owner review because eligibility, partner commitments, costs, and evidence cannot be verified from the website.

Practical test

The source packet is sufficient for drafting only when someone unfamiliar with the project can answer:

- Who benefits?
- What exactly happens?
- Who delivers it?
- Why should the result occur?
- What does it cost?
- What remains after funding?

If any answer is missing, the next step is research or a project decision—not proposal prose.

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The packet needs to be specific enough that a drafter cannot make silent choices. Add definitions, permitted claims, missing-information rules, and examples of unacceptable inferences so the website cannot be overinterpreted.

Input specification

Provide each item in a fixed format rather than as general notes.

Input	Required fields	Example of sufficient detail	Still insufficient
Applicant	Legal name, jurisdiction, tax status, controller, registration status	“ABC LLC, Delaware; taxed as partnership; registered September 1”	“Our company”
Beneficiary	Inclusion, exclusion, geography, estimated number, source	“SF residents aged 16–24 without paid creative-work experience; estimate and source stated”	“Youth”
Problem	Condition, cause, local scale, source, limitation	“X% lack access, according to named source; source does not measure skills”	“Opportunities are limited”
Pathway	Step, duration, location, deliverer, completion rule	“Twelve facilitated weekly sessions at named site”	“Participants use the platform”
Delivery capacity	Named staff hours, facility status, cohort size	“One facilitator can run two cohorts weekly”	“We can scale”

Input	Required fields	Example of sufficient detail	Still insufficient
Partner	Name, role, status, written confirmation	“In discussion; no delivery commitment”	“Supported by local organizations”
Evidence	Citation, population, finding, limitation, grade	“Comparable program; different city and age group”	“Research shows games work”
Cost	Unit, quantity, price, source, period	“Facilitator: 10 hours/week × $X × 40 weeks”	“Personnel: 30%”
Rights	Asset, owner, license, restriction	“Music licensed for noncommercial web use only”	“We own everything”
Durability	Retained activity, owner, annual cost, funding source	“School maintains club; annual cost stated”	“The community sustains it”

Every field marked unknown should literally say “unknown.” A blank space can be mistaken for permission to infer an answer.

Drafter constraints

Give the drafter these written instructions:

- Use only facts in the source packet and documents it cites.
- Do not infer demand, outcomes, partnerships, capacity, ownership, or eligibility from the website.
- Label missing information explicitly.
- Use “planning target” for quantities not supported by operating history.
- Use relationship statuses exactly as supplied.
- Do not add a beneficiary, activity, partner, or outcome to make the proposal more compelling.
- Preserve limitations attached to evidence.
- Stop and request information when a required field is unknown.

The drafter may improve clarity and organization, but may not resolve project-design choices.

Inference boundaries

State these prohibitions directly:

Website observation	Permitted statement	Prohibited inference
A game is playable	The listed game is publicly accessible	It improves learning or employment
The arcade has several titles	Those titles are available	Users form a community or pipeline
A work-in-progress warning appears	The product remains under development	It is ready for citywide deployment
No account is required	Access has the stated technical condition	The target population can realistically use it
The site loads in a browser	Browser access is possible	San Francisco institutions will adopt it

Website observation	Permitted statement	Prohibited inference
The team built the site	The team has product-development capability	The team can deliver education or social services

This prevents product facts from being silently promoted into impact claims.

Missing-information protocol

For every unknown required field, the draft should insert a visible marker:

> **[INFORMATION NEEDED: responsible owner; why required; decision blocked]**

Examples:

- **[INFORMATION NEEDED: San Francisco delivery partner; required to support viability; blocks implementation claim]**
- **[INFORMATION NEEDED: facilitator unit cost; required to calculate request; blocks budget]**
- **[INFORMATION NEEDED: music-license scope; required to confirm permitted use; blocks rights claim]**

The marker stays until the owner supplies the fact. Deleting it without new information is a failed draft, even if the paragraph reads more smoothly.

Source packet structure

Ask your team to complete ten short statements before drafting:

1. “The legal applicant is [entity], organized in [jurisdiction], with [tax status].”
2. “The project serves [included population] in [San Francisco geography], excluding [groups].”
3. “The current problem is [condition], affecting [quantity or unknown scale], based on [source].”
4. “A participant will [complete pathway], requiring [hours] over [period].”
5. “FTSArcade will provide [functions], but will not provide [human services].”
6. “First-year capacity is [cohorts], limited by [staff, facilities, recruitment, or budget].”
7. “The evidence for the mechanism is [grade and source], limited by [difference].”
8. “The request is [amount], calculated from [attached cost model].”
9. “After the grant, [named party] will maintain [asset or activity] at [annual cost].”
10. “The proposal must not claim [prohibited outcomes or relationships].”

If any statement cannot be completed, the proposal can still contain a placeholder, but it cannot be treated as finished.

Acceptance test for a draft

Accept the first draft only if:

- Every factual sentence maps to the packet.
- Every unknown is visibly marked.
- No partner status has been upgraded.
- No website feature has acquired an unsupported outcome.
- The budget matches the stated cohort and staffing levels.
- The first-year plan fits stated capacity.
- The weakest assumption remains visible.
- A reviewer can distinguish facts, plans, and assumptions without asking the writer.

If these conditions fail, correct the draft or source packet. Do not compensate by adding more persuasive language.

Recommended handoff

The practical handoff is therefore:

1. Completed ten-statement source packet
2. Evidence and budget attachments
3. Platform boundary and prohibited claims
4. Website address
5. Methodology and drafter constraints
6. Exact application questions and word limits, when available

That package is enough for a **controlled first draft with explicit gaps**. It becomes enough for a submission-ready proposal only after every information marker affecting eligibility, delivery, outcomes, rights, or cost has been resolved and verified.

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The handoff can be made reproducible by adding a coverage check, a draft-output format, and quantitative acceptance rules. This lets you determine whether the writer followed the source packet instead of judging the proposal by whether it sounds persuasive.

Coverage matrix

Before drafting, assign every required proposal element one status.

Element	Status	Meaning	Draft treatment
Complete	All required fields and sources present	Writer may use it	Integrate normally
Partial	Core fact present, limitation missing	Writer may use only stated portion	Preserve limitation

Element	Status	Meaning	Draft treatment
Contested	Sources or owners disagree	No preferred version chosen	Show unresolved conflict
Unknown	Required fact absent	No inference permitted	Insert information marker
Prohibited	Team explicitly rejects claim	Cannot be used even if plausible	Omit

A complete-looking proposal is not acceptable if any central element remains unknown or contested. Those statuses must remain visible.

Required draft format

Ask for two outputs, not one polished document.

Output A: annotated draft

Each paragraph ends with an internal trace:

> Source: C1, C4; Figures: F2; Evidence: E4; Status: assumption labeled.

Traces can be removed after review, but their presence makes unsupported additions easy to detect.

Output B: exception report

The writer must separately list:

- Information markers and why each blocks a claim
- Source conflicts
- Claims considered but rejected
- Website observations intentionally not used
- Assumptions that materially affect viability, cost, or outcomes
- Any place where available evidence was too weak to answer an application criterion

If the exception report is empty on the first draft, treat that as a warning sign. A project at this stage should have unresolved issues.

Scoring the draft

Use this review score before discussing writing quality.

Test	Pass rule
Traceability	At least 95% of factual sentences map to a source ID
No silent inference	Zero unsupported website-derived claims
Status fidelity	100% of partner and evidence statuses preserved
Gap visibility	100% of unknown required fields marked

Test	Pass rule
Numerical consistency	All figures match the data dictionary and budget
Capacity consistency	Planned volume does not exceed stated capacity
Prohibited claims	Zero prohibited claims appear
Criterion coverage	Every rubric criterion is answered or explicitly blocked

A draft can be clearly written and still fail. It passes only after meeting every rule above.

Paragraph acceptance

Review each paragraph with five yes-or-no questions:

1. Does the first sentence state its claim?
2. Can the claim be traced?
3. Is its certainty correctly labeled?
4. Does it add exactly one new idea?
5. Would deleting it remove useful information rather than tone?

Retain the paragraph only if all five answers are yes. Otherwise revise or delete it.

Red-team protocol

Have one reviewer actively try to make the draft fail. Their task is not to improve tone but to find:

- A claim without a source
- A causal leap
- A partner whose role exceeds confirmation
- A number with no denominator or period
- A cost not tied to an activity
- A first-year promise requiring unsigned capacity
- A post-grant benefit without an owner
- A platform feature presented as a human service
- A limitation omitted from the narrative

Each finding is classified as:

- **Correct:** Fix the source or draft.
- **Already disclosed:** No action.
- **Requires project decision:** Return to decision register.
- **Speculative objection:** Record it, but do not expand the proposal merely to answer it.

Final handoff checklist

The writer receives exactly these files:

1. Ten-statement source packet
2. Coverage matrix
3. Claim ledger and evidence grades
4. Data dictionary
5. Participant pathway
6. Platform boundary and prohibited claims
7. Delivery capacity and partner statuses
8. Budget workbook and selected scenario
9. Rights schedule
10. Decision and revision registers
11. Drafter constraints
12. Application questions and limits, if available
13. Website URL

The writer should not receive old pitches, informal brainstorming notes, or alternative visions unless they have been accepted in the decision register. Extra material creates opportunities for retired claims to re-enter the draft.

Definition of a usable result

The resulting draft is usable when a reviewer can, without asking the writer:

- Trace every material claim
- Identify every blocking unknown
- Reproduce the budget from the stated activities
- Distinguish confirmed, discussed, and proposed relationships
- State the weakest assumption
- Determine whether the draft is ready, partially blocked, or not yet eligible

That is the correct standard. The website supplies product context, while this packet and its controls determine whether the resulting proposal is disciplined enough to review and eventually submit.

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The final layer is a small operating manual for the person managing the writer. It defines the assignment, the order of work, escalation rules, and the conditions under which drafting must stop. This prevents both unsupported invention and endless rewriting.

Writer assignment

Give the writer this scope:

> Draft only what the approved source packet supports. Make gaps visible, preserve uncertainty, and do not improve the project by adding unstated activities, partners, outcomes, capacity, or evidence. Where a rubric criterion cannot be answered, say that it is blocked and identify the missing input.

The writer's deliverables should be:

1. Annotated prospectus draft
2. Exception report
3. Traceability table
4. List of questions requiring a decision
5. Application-answer draft, only after the prospectus passes review

No slide deck, pitch rewrite, or alternative concept is part of the assignment unless separately approved.

Work order

Require the writer to proceed in this order:

1. Read the prohibited claims and coverage matrix.
2. List every unknown or contested central element.
3. Draft the participant pathway and first-year plan.
4. Draft evidence, budget, and durability only from approved figures.
5. Draft the theory of change.
6. Write the summary last.
7. Add paragraph traces.
8. Run the scoring tests.
9. Submit the exception report with the draft.

This order ensures the summary cannot introduce a claim that the body has not accepted.

Escalation rules

The writer must stop and request a decision when encountering:

- Two sources giving different figures
- A partner role stronger than its documented status
- A budget total that cannot be reproduced
- A required activity without an owner
- A claim graded E5 that appears essential

- Eligibility information that is missing or inconsistent
- Rights that do not cover the proposed use
- A first-year plan exceeding stated capacity
- An application question with no corresponding source material

The writer should not select the “most reasonable” resolution. The escalation note should quote the conflict, list the affected claims, and state which decision owner must resolve it.

Question format

Every question returned to the team should use this format:

> **Decision needed:** [specific choice]
> **Why blocked:** [claim or section affected]
> **Options:** [only options supported by current material, plus “none approved”]
> **Consequence:** [what cannot be claimed until resolved]
> **Owner:** [one person]
> **Needed by:** [date]

This prevents broad questions such as “Can you clarify the impact?” which invite another round of vague vision writing.

Review cycle

Use no more than three cycles.

Cycle	Purpose	Permitted changes	Output
Cycle 1	Establish fidelity	Correct traces, gaps, and contradictions	Usable annotated draft
Cycle 2	Resolve decisions	Incorporate newly approved source changes	Revised draft and updated registers
Cycle 3	Compress and polish	Shorten without changing meaning	Submission-oriented text

After Cycle 3, new ideas go into a future-version list rather than the current draft. This protects the deadline and the audit trail.

Manager’s review checklist

Before accepting the draft, the manager checks:

- Writer did not add a beneficiary, partner, activity, or outcome.
- All central unknowns remain marked.
- Summary contains no claim absent from the body.
- Budget figures match the workbook exactly.
- Evidence language matches assigned grades.
- Prohibited claims are absent.
- Exception report explains every blocked rubric criterion.

- Questions request decisions rather than more prose.
- Application answers, if present, match frozen prospectus text.

If any check fails, return the draft with the failed rule identified. Do not give open-ended feedback such as “make it stronger.”

Stop conditions

Stop drafting entirely when:

- The applicant is not confirmed eligible.
- Registration status prevents submission.
- No beneficiary or intervention has been approved.
- The budget cannot explain the request.
- Essential rights are unresolved.
- The team wants the writer to invent missing evidence or partners.

In those cases, the appropriate product is a gap report, not another proposal draft.

Completed operating package

The full methodology now consists of:

- Source packet and coverage matrix
- Claim, evidence, decision, and revision registers
- Platform boundary and prohibited inferences
- Budget, capacity, and traceability controls
- Writer assignment, work order, and escalation rules
- Scoring tests and three-cycle review limit
- Stop conditions and manager checklist

That is sufficient to commission a **faithful first draft**. It is enough for a final proposal only after the team replaces every blocking information marker with verified source material and approves the resulting changes through the decision register.

more

The package can be completed with a one-page operating charter and a set of acceptance records. These make the methodology enforceable: every person can see what they may decide, what the writer must return, and when the draft is ready to move forward.

Operating charter

Purpose: Produce a faithful, reviewable proposal from approved sources without inventing missing facts.

Authoritative inputs: The approved source packet, registers, budget, rights schedule, and decision record override the website, prior pitches, and conversation.

Writer authority: The writer may organize, clarify, shorten, and identify gaps. The writer may not create project substance.

Team authority: Owners supply and approve facts in their areas. Only the designated decision owner may close a foundational choice.

Conflict rule: When sources conflict, drafting pauses for that claim. No one silently chooses the more compelling version.

Gap rule: Unknown required information remains visibly marked until a source is supplied.

Change rule: New ideas enter through the decision register before entering the prospectus.

Finish rule: A polished narrative is not complete unless its claims, numbers, responsibilities, and costs trace to approved sources.

Role cards

Role	Sole authority	Must supply	Cannot delegate
Decision owner	Foundational choices	Written rationale	Beneficiary, lead, outcome, funding scenario
Program owner	Intervention and delivery	Pathway, capacity, partner status	Unconfirmed commitments
Evidence owner	Evidence grades	Sources and limitations	Upgrading certainty
Budget owner	Costs and scenarios	Reproducible calculations	Narrative-only figures
Rights owner	Asset permissions	Ownership and restrictions	Assumed licenses
Writer	Presentation	Traces and exception report	Project decisions
Manager	Process acceptance	Review record	Overriding subject owners
Signatory	Final submission	Approval statement	Signing unresolved central gaps

One person may hold multiple roles, but the record should still identify which role approved each item.

Acceptance records

Use four short records rather than informal approval messages.

Source acceptance

> I approve [document/version] as source material for [scope]. It contains [number] unresolved items, none of which affect [or do affect] central claims.

Decision acceptance

> I select [option] because [reason]. Options rejected: [options]. Documents requiring revision: [documents].

Draft acceptance

> Cycle [number] passes the manager checklist. Exceptions remain in [sections]. New ideas deferred: [list].

Submission acceptance

> I confirm that eligibility, central claims, budget, rights, and partner statuses have been verified or are accurately disclosed. I authorize submission of [version].

Each record needs a name, role, date, and document version.

Version labels

Use consistent labels so reviewers know what they are reading.

Label	Meaning	Permitted use
S0	Incomplete source packet	Gap identification only
S1	Approved for drafting	Controlled draft
D1	First fidelity draft	Review, not submission
D2	Decision revisions incorporated	Further review
D3	Compressed and polished	Application preparation
F	Frozen submission version	Submission only
X	Rejected or superseded	Historical reference only

No file should circulate without a label and date. Superseded files remain available for audit but cannot be mined for new claims.

Handoff message

Use this instruction with the writer:

> Using only the attached S1 sources, produce an annotated prospectus, traceability table, and exception report. Do not infer missing facts from the website. Preserve all limitations and relationship statuses. If a central element is unknown, contested, or prohibited, mark it and explain the blocked claim. Return questions in the required decision format. Do not draft final application answers until D1 passes review.

That message, together with the charter and source package, is the complete writing brief.

Final readiness states

State	Definition	Next action
Not ready	Beneficiary, intervention, eligibility, or budget absent	Complete source packet
Draftable	S1 sources approved, gaps visible	Commission D1
Reviewable	D1 traces and exception report complete	Run audits
Revisable	Decisions returned and approved	Produce D2
Compressible	Claims stable and contradictions resolved	Produce D3
Submittable	F version approved and portal answers verified	Submit
Blocked	Eligibility, rights, or central evidence unresolved	Stop and obtain decision

The methodology is now sufficient to govern the work from source collection through submission. It does not replace the missing project facts: it tells the team exactly when those facts are adequate, how a writer may use them, and when drafting must pause rather than conceal a gap.

what's the latest deadline

The latest published application deadline is Thursday, October 15, 2026, at 5 p.m. U.S. Pacific Time. The deadline was extended from October 9, 2026. [75]

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here's the full roster of services and products we can offer:

- people (the house) business can order the arcade from us
- we both develop the cabinet, the games inside, specific games people / business want we put inside it
- the full upsell environment (hidden from now) though promotional is the eco-system we promote around san Francisco, old buildings, that are getting rejuvinated, the running

routes (we have data) and everything that can popularize the city, we'll be putting actual landmarks into the games + business inside them, offering ad-space and everything else included

- we will also kind of be supporting our own economy inside of that, very liberal and very throughput
- customers have promotional stickers, we ill be issuing QR codes, so that you can play the game and get an uber after that

This is a viable product roster, but it is not yet a grant proposal. It describes several businesses—cabinet sales, custom game development, city promotion, advertising, and ride referrals—that must be separated before any can support the application. The competition funds a charitable project that primarily benefits San Francisco, not a commercial expansion merely because it features the city. [76]

Separate the businesses

Offering	What it appears to be	How it can enter the proposal
Arcade cabinets for businesses	Commercial product sale	Permitted only as a means to a defined charitable outcome, with no more than incidental private benefit [76]
Custom cabinet and game development	Commercial service	Must have a documented charitable purpose, buyer, budget, and result
Games featuring landmarks and local businesses	City-promotion and advertising platform	Business promotion cannot itself be the public benefit
Internal game economy	Transaction or rewards system	Needs a lawful, charitable purpose and strong controls
Stickers, QR codes, and Uber referrals	Marketing and commercial referral mechanism	Not a charitable outcome without evidence of public benefit

The first necessary decision is which **one public outcome** this portfolio serves. Economic activity, tourism, advertising, and convenience are mechanisms or business features, not automatically benefits to San Franciscans.

What must not be claimed yet

The current description does not support claims that the project will:

- Revitalize old buildings
- Increase running or use of public routes
- Popularize San Francisco
- Produce economic development
- Benefit participating businesses equitably
- Improve mobility merely because a QR code links to Uber

Those may become research questions or separately funded commercial activities. They should not appear as promised outcomes unless each has a beneficiary, mechanism, evidence grade,

delivery owner, and budget.

Choose a charitable frame

A potentially admissible framing is:

> Provide publicly accessible cultural and recreational game installations that document and increase engagement with specific San Francisco places, while any advertising or commerce funds free public access.

That is only a hypothesis. It still needs a defined beneficiary, site plan, access rules, and evidence connecting gameplay to a public benefit.

For that framing, the proposal would need to explain:

- Which residents or visitors benefit, and how
- Which buildings, routes, or landmarks are included
- What permission their owners or responsible authorities have given
- Why featuring them changes conditions rather than merely advertising them
- How much access remains free
- Who controls advertising standards and business selection
- Why commercial revenues do not become the project's real purpose

Build the source claims

I would reduce the roster to these initially admissible claims:

1. The team can develop custom arcade cabinets.
2. The team can develop and install custom games.
3. Businesses will be able to order installations, subject to confirmed demand.
4. Games can potentially incorporate licensed San Francisco locations and businesses.
5. QR codes can connect gameplay to separately approved partner offers.
6. Commercial revenue is being investigated as one sustainability mechanism.

Each claim still requires an owner and evidence. "We have running-route data" needs its source, date, permissions, and relevance. "Customers want cabinets" needs orders, letters of intent, or a clearly labeled assumption.

Commercial-benefit test

Before adding any business feature, ask:

1. What charitable result does it produce?
2. Who pays, and who benefits?
3. Would the feature still belong if it generated no revenue?

4. Could it advantage the company or advertisers more than the public?
5. What rule prevents excessive private benefit?
6. What happens to public access if advertising disappears?

If the honest answer to the third question is no, the feature probably belongs in the business plan rather than the grant narrative.

The next step is to choose between two project identities: a **public cultural-installation program** supported by commercial activity, or a **commercial arcade business** with civic branding. Only the first is likely to fit this competition, and only after its public benefit is defined much more precisely.

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